



MAN IN CHARGE:
Nehru at
HMT's
Bangalore
plant in
1955

E.P.W. DA COSTA, editor, *Eastern Economist*, 1956

**"India's
expanding needs
are driving her
hard in search of
a new route to
prosperity."**

opposite to ours. That is public interest trumps private rights, every time. So Pudong, home to many of the *Fortune 500*, can be built literally overnight on the banks of Shanghai's Huangpu river, whereas building a simple airport in Bangalore is painful to watch.

How the public sector fell into relative disrepute is not as clear-cut as blaming our politicians and bureaucrats. No one is blameless in a complex choreography of abdication of responsibility, denial and finger-pointing. The private sector, in particular, cannot stand absolved of its responsibility.

On the one hand, significant elements abetted the government during the much-reviled licence raj. On the other, it has not been creative enough in initiating a jugalbandi. No meaningful joint creation of public assets has come to pass. The best way to illustrate what we missed out on is to consider some incredibly promising efforts underway today.

PRS Legislative Research, born as Parliamentary Research Services, brings in private-sector efficiency to help strengthen India's democratic process. It is C.V. Madhukar's attempt to inform parliamentarians about pending legislation by providing world-class briefs on the issues at hand. Another is India Inc.

Going Global—a forum launched by a group of Indian MNCs under the auspices of the Confederation of Indian Industry, where those investing overseas interface with the government on issues of importance.

There are initiatives from the government too. One of particular interest is the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas as it reverses the government's historical inattention to the Indian diaspora. Whereas China's diaspora catalysed its development trajectory, India's was held at arm's-length for the longest time.

The contours of the ensuing public sector-private sector jugalbandi can now be seen in the efforts of these projects. They will help us move towards a better balance than that historically struck between public interest and private rights. The much-needed investment in public assets can then be spearheaded by the public sector, but the private sector and civil society can also be judiciously used as catalysts and instruments to achieve this goal.

The author is the Jorge Paulo Lemann Professor at Harvard Business School. This essay draws on his forthcoming book Billions of Entrepreneurs: How China and India are Reshaping their Futures, and Yours.